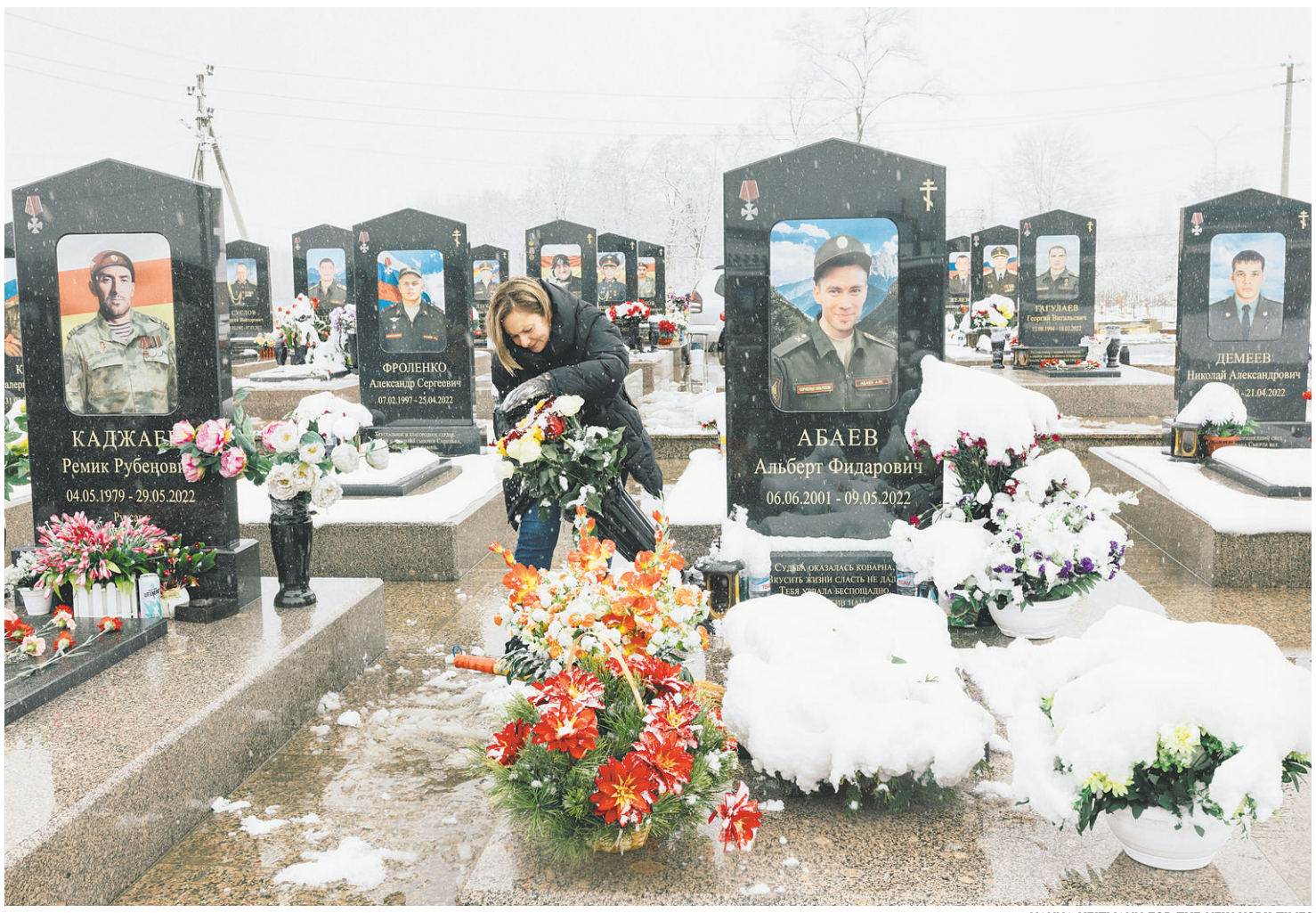
"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, cloudy, a shower in the morning, high 70. **Tonight,** clear, light and variable winds, low 58. **Tomorrow,** sunshine mixed with some clouds, high 73. Weather map is on Page D8.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,035 © 2026 The New York Times Company MONDAY, OCTOBER 12, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00



NANNA HEITMANN FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Pulled Between Pride and Loss
North Ossetia, Russia, has suffered a heavy toll, yet many accept the Kremlin's line that the war in Ukraine must continue. Page A8.

Inside the Crisis Response At Cornell's Chi Phi House

Texts Reveal Scramble After Sexual Assault Claim: 'What's the Plan of Action?'

By MICHAEL WILSON

The brothers of Chi Phi were texting one another in a panic.

On the afternoon of Nov. 8, 2024, Cornell University suspended the fraternity for suspected drug use. Three hours later, the school sent an email blast with the subject line "Crime ALERT: Sexual Assault — Edgemoor Lane, City of Ithaca."

It read: "The victim reported being sexually assaulted by several males and coerced into consuming ketamine and other drugs."

The Chi Phi house was indeed on Edgemoor Lane, and there was a night the brothers were worried about. But a simple detail in the email gave them fleeting hope.

"Dates don't add up," one man wrote to the other three brothers in the chat. Was the suspension notice referring maybe to a different Chi Phi party? Was that Risky Business Night? The more likely date the email was describing, they feared, was Oct. 19, 2024: Hawaiian Night, when things had gotten out of hand with a sorority sister.

"What's the plan of action?" Matthew Ingalls, a sophomore studying math and economics, wrote. He had been in touch with the woman from Hawaiian Night several times since the party, text messages showed, and he had offered to call her again.

"I don't think she would have reported this," Mr. Ingalls offered to the group text.

He was wrong.

The woman, now known as Jane Doe, would go on to file a lawsuit describing a night at the Chi Phi house that began with a threesome with two of the brothers on the text chain but was followed by sex acts with several other Chi Phi brothers.

Those encounters, which Jane Doe said took place while she was incapacitated by ketamine and liquor, were, she later came to believe, a crime.

This article is based on a cache of documents collected during the university's sexual assault investigation and obtained by The New York Times. Across more than 1,000 pages, the records paint a lurid picture of life inside the Tudor mansion of the Xi chapter of Chi Phi — one at odds with the "house on the hill," as the fraternity's website described it, that "still stands today as a monument to the ideals of brotherhood for which this chapter was founded."

Judging from the lawsuit and even the accused brothers' own statements, those ideals had warped and devolved inside that house on Hawaiian Night. And the events of that evening and the days that followed all played out over texts that were later submitted to investigators — texts seeming to invite anyone in the fraternity to join the brothers having sex with Jane Doe, and later ones urging calm as rumors spread.

In the wake of Hawaiian Night, the Chi Phi brothers seemed to have reason to believe that things might just return to normal. Various brothers reached out to Jane Doe with texts that sought to confirm everything was good.

"I just wanted to apologize for how things went down the other night," one brother, Jonathan Newell, texted Jane Doe the following Monday, Oct. 21, 2024. He apologized repeatedly for being "too fucked up" to have prevented other Chi Phi brothers from entering the bedroom.

"We've been shutting down any stories we've heard," he wrote. "But again I'm so so sorry."

Jane Doe had gone to the party to see another brother, Mr. Ingalls, at the end of a very bad day. Some-

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INQUIRY TARGETS TV POOL BOYCOTT

Justice Dept. Is Looking for an Antitrust Case

This article is by ***David McCabe, Michael M. Grynbaum, Benjamin Mullin, Lauren Hirsch*** *and* ***Glenn Thrush****.*

The Justice Department is investigating whether the major television networks — ABC, CBS, CNN, NBC and Fox News — violated federal antitrust laws when the group briefly suspended their pooled coverage of President Trump, according to six people with knowledge of the department's action.

Officials from the Justice Department contacted networks on Friday and demanded communications and materials related to the White House TV pool, the people said. The pool is a longstanding system where the networks share the responsibility of providing footage of the president and distributing it to other news outlets.

Last month, the networks collectively suspended their pool footage of Mr. Trump for several days after the president barred CNN journalists from the White House grounds, which prevented CNN from participating in the pool. Video footage of some major events, including Mr. Trump's greeting of President Xi Jinping of China, was not carried by any major news station.

In a statement on Saturday, a Justice Department spokeswoman, Emily Covington, described the five networks as having "proudly boycotted covering White House events."

"Group boycotts among commercial competitors can violate the Sherman Act," a core antitrust law, Ms. Covington wrote. "The Antitrust Division is simply investigating to determine whether these news organizations have violated the antitrust laws."

The inquiry by the Justice Department is a profound escalation of the Trump administration's ongoing battles with the White House press corps. It also follows a pattern of the Trump administration using the levers of government against its perceived foes in the media. The Justice Department has subpoenaed reporters from The New York Times and seized a laptop from a Washington

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Where They Say Every Tree Conceals an Enemy

A Reporter Returns to a China Hushed by Intense Paranoia

By ANDREW HIGGINS

CHINA DISPATCH

TAIYUAN, China — It was an enjoyable day of temple and factory visits organized by China Daily, the Communist Party's English-language mouthpiece, but it ended on an uncomfortable note.

The group I was traveling with in the province of Shanxi — mostly foreign influencers hungry for followers and Chinese freebies — was told to line up behind a long banner and be filmed chanting, "Amazing China, Amazing Shanxi."

I declined to join in, scowling in silence. But, back in my hotel room in the provincial capital of Taiyuan, I thought I had perhaps been too churlish: Getting a bunch of foreigners to chant on cue for the camera about China's wonders was a transparent but harmless propaganda stunt.

And, to be honest, the 11th-century temples we visited — and also the new highway that took us to them — were pretty amazing.

I then received a message on WeChat, a Chinese messaging app, from an old friend in Beijing, a lawyer whose earnest decency and movie-star looks always reminded me of the "good party cadre" characters in propaganda films. I had not seen him for more than 30 years and was planning to visit the next day.

Sadly, his message said, he would not be able to keep our appointment because state secu-

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HILARY SWIFT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Recovering From a Storm
Irma Basquet cooking in Milton, Fla., after Hurricane Isaias cut power to her complex. Page A18.

Alarm for G.O.P. as Voters Curse the Economy

Trump's Unpopularity Digs Hole for Party

By PATRICIA MAZZEI and SHANE GOLDMACHER

Less than three weeks from Election Day, deep frustration over an economy that feels unworkable for Americans at most every level, from farmers to truckers to consumers, has expanded the map of competitive electoral contests into areas that seemed safely Republican just a couple of months ago.

Sustained high prices are putting at risk some of the constituencies, states and congressional districts that President Trump and Republicans won decisively in 2024. The widespread discontent has prompted candidates, parties and major G.O.P. fund-raising groups to shift their messages and ad spending in crucial races to try to move voters in the final days of the midterm campaign.

With control of the House, Senate and the vast majority of the country's governor's offices and legislatures at stake, Republicans are examining their own deteriorating internal polling, along with their experiences with voters, and say they are reassessing their odds and triaging the map.

On Friday, for example, the leading Senate Republican super PAC began to plunge another $30 million into advertising in Texas to try to save the state's Senate seat for Ken Paxton, the Republican attorney general.

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Young Bass Fishers Seek Out A Big Haul: Money for Tuition

By KEN BELSON

BUCHANAN, Tenn. — Just before sunrise on a Saturday in August, 25 boats bobbed in the marina at Paris Landing State Park in Buchanan, Tenn., awaiting the start of the final round of the most prestigious event in high school bass fishing.

After "The Star-Spangled Banner" was played, the boats sped onto 184-mile-long Kentucky Lake in search of bass, the heavier the better.

Caige Bragg, a lanky 18-year-old Alabaman who was in first place, motored about 10 minutes south of the marina where he knew the fishing would be fruitful.

Eight hours later, Mr. Bragg returned to the marina and handed the tournament's organizer a mesh bag with his catch. At a combined 11 pounds 3 ounces, the three fish were enough to secure him the championship, beating out 213 other teams.

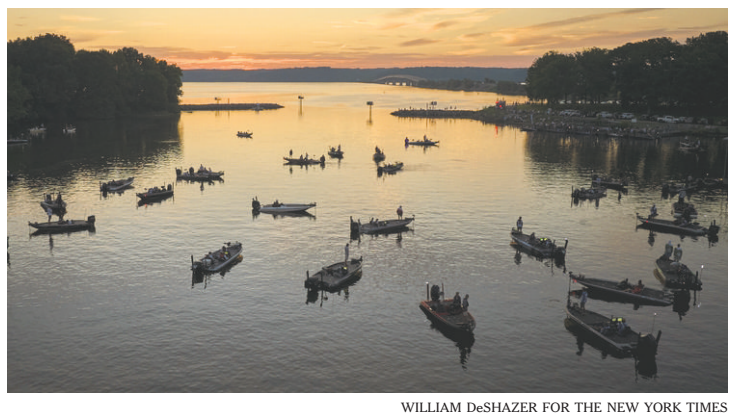
For winning the Strike King Bassmaster High School National Championship, Mr. Bragg received a $25,000 boat and a $5,000 college scholarship.

"I just love fishing for bass, to be honest," he said. "There's always a puzzle every time. It's kind of like chess."

Competitive bass fishing has been around for about 60 years, but in the past decade or two, it has turned into high-stakes pro sport complete with star anglers, big sponsors and media deals. The chance to make a living with a rod, reel and boat — or at least get a college scholarship from it — has in turn spawned a growing number of youth fishing programs across the country.

The sport's sanctioning body, BASS Nation, short for Bass Anglers Sportsman Society, has about 12,000 anglers in 1,100 high

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WILLIAM DeSHAZER FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Waiting to start competitive bass fishing in Buchanan, Tenn.

INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Saudi Arabia Has Few Options
The Houthis' attacks on a Saudi airport highlight the nature of their strife with the kingdom. News Analysis. PAGE A5

Inuit Identity Fuels Art
In Canada's Arctic, creatives are turning questions of language and land into books, films and even tattoos. PAGE A4

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An Unexpected Battleground
Republicans are racing to defend a seat in Kansas, where Democrats are trying to win a Senate race for the first time in nearly a century. PAGE A10

Creating Political Ammunition
A release of selected records from the classified documents inquiry shows how the White House and its allies feed a "weaponization" narrative. PAGE A13

Hochul Backs Voucher Plan
The governor's decision to sign on to the president's tax-credit program for education has put her at odds with New York's teachers' unions. PAGE A12

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Building a new nuclear plant is a long process, so companies are retrofitting existing reactors so they can satisfy the rise in demand for electricity. PAGE B1

'ChatGPT for Teens' Red Flags
A.I. chatbots for schoolwork may stifle students' abilities to retain information and solve complex problems. PAGE B1

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Collector of Sports Teams
George Gillett Jr., 87, once owned the Globetrotters, the Canadiens and the Liverpool soccer club. PAGE B7

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Puzzles to Explode Your Mind
Jonathan Blow has long wondered how the universe runs. In a new video game, players can join in his obsession. PAGE C1

Her Side of the Story
In a new documentary, Ashley St. Clair, a former partner of Elon Musk, talks about her relationship with him. PAGE C1

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Throwbacks Power Guardians
Led by a pitcher who won't give up the ball and a slugger who won't give up on his city, Cleveland marches on. PAGE D1

Games Take Strange Turns
The college football top 25 faced a reshuffling after some unusual results in rivalry matchups. PAGE D3

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Jessica Grose PAGE A17



